



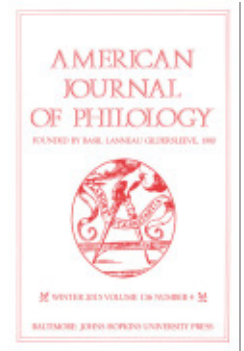
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A Tale of Two Commanders: Ammianus Marcellinus on the Campaigns of Constantius II and Julian on the Northern Frontiers

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A TALE OF TWO COMMANDERS:
AMMIANUS MARCELLINUS ON THE CAMPAIGNS
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THE NORTHERN FRONTIERS

MOYSÉS MARCOS



Abstract. Ammianus Marcellinus is a careful manipulator of language and narrative structure. This article seeks to show through literary analysis that his description of the Emperor Constantius II (*ut cunctator et cautus*, 14.10.14) is not meant to be a positive evaluation but a negative one, especially when compared with how Ammianus renders the Caesar Julian (*bellicosus dux*, 16.12.18), with consequences for how we should read Ammianus. Despite his failure to elaborate on Constantius' second campaign in Raetia in 356 C.E. (16.12.15–16), or the possible loss of an earlier telling of the campaign via corruption of the textual transmission (Barnes 1998, 138), Ammianus' is the fullest account available; and, in fact, there is enough in what we do know about the campaigning seasons of 354–59 on the northern frontiers to be able to discern Constantius and Julian's strategies, and thus what each considered to be “achievement.”

FOR SOME TIME NOW, studies of Ammianus, such as Barnes (1998) and, more recently, Kelly (2008), have shown just how subtle and clever a writer this last great Latin historian is.¹ Scholars succeeding Blockley (1973; 1975) and Seager (1986), who have made some important contributions to our understanding of Ammianus' language and thought, have increasingly looked at Ammianus' careful use of language in his representation of figures in the *Res Gestae*. In fact, the philological and historical commentaries on Ammianus' eighteen extant books are set to be completed within the next few years.² In a short but revealing paper, Seager focused on a particular description of the Emperor Valentinian I at 27.10.10, where Ammianus describes this emperor *ut dux cunctator et tutus* or “like a reluctant and wary general.”³ This would appear to be a

¹The text of Ammianus used throughout this article is that of Seyfarth's critical edition.

²Only the commentary on Book remains to be done.

³Seager 1996. Cf. den Boeft et al. 2009, 240–41. On Ammianus' overall portrayal of Valentinian, see Teitler 2007.

positive evaluation, but, as Seager has shown, it is actually an ironic usage, for immediately after deploying it, Ammianus tells us that Valentinian allowed himself to ride into an ambush (27.10.11). Thus, Valentinian is not actually *dux cunctator et tutus*. By considering language and its context in tandem, as in this episode of Valentinian, we are better able to detect Ammianus' subversion of language and grasp his intended meaning elsewhere.

Ammianus does not limit himself to such purposeful depiction of an imperial figure in a single case; he also consistently makes direct comparisons throughout his work.⁴ For example, just to cite a few instances, at 14.11.28, Gallus Caesar is compared to Domitian, and Julian to Titus; at 15.2.5, the *magister equitum* Ursicinus is compared to the Neronian general Domitius Corbulo; and at 29.5.32, we see Theodosius the Elder placed alongside the Republican general Quintus Fabius Maximus (*ut antiquus ille Cunctator*), who had faced off against Hannibal in the Second Punic War (see below). However, Ammianus also makes subtle pairings in his text. Indeed, as Blockley (1994, 61) has noted, "Ammianus is a writer of both complexity and subtlety." For example, just to cite a few instances, at 15.2.5, by comparing Ursicinus to Domitius Corbulo, Ammianus is therefore also indirectly comparing Constantius II to Nero; at 15.4.7–8, Ammianus describes the ambush of the *magister equitum* Arbitio, Constantius' proxy, in language ("Having been lured into a hidden trap, he [Arbitio] stood motionless since he was struck by the sudden misfortune . . . [suddenly?] the hostiles leapt forth from their hiding places," *in occultas delatus insidias stetit immobilis malo repentino percussus. . . . uisi e latebris hostes exsiliunt*) that is similar to how he later relates an ambush of Julian ("He [Julian] stood for a long time in a state of [proper] reluctance since he had been informed by the disclosure of a deserter that a great many men, who were concealed in certain hidden underground [places] and numerous interconnected trenches, would, when it seemed convenient, burst forth," *stetit diu cunctando indicio perfugae doctus per subterranea quaedam occulta fossasque multifidas latere plurimos, ubi habile uisum fuerit, erupturos*, 17.1.8), who eventually comes off better;⁵ at 17.4.5, the Caesar Gallus is compared to Cornelius Gallus,

⁴On Ammianus' use of *exempla*, see Blockley 1975, 157–67, 191–94; 1994; Kelly 2005; 2008, 256–95.

⁵*PLRE* 1.94–95, Flavius Arbitio 2. On Ammianus' use of *stetit immobilis*, see Fontaine 1982. This ambush of Julian at 17.1.8, where the Caesar *stetit diu cunctando*, also seems to be an allusion to 16.2.11, where Julian is styled *prouidus et cunctator* (more below) in the context of an ambush during his first campaign in Gaul in 356.

Augustus' disgraced Prefect of Egypt;⁶ and at 23.1.1, Julian is paired off with Diocletian.⁷

It has been well established that Julian is the hero, in every sense of the word (a protagonist of a story and also a semi-divine figure or demigod), of Ammianus' grand narrative, often to the detriment of Constantius.⁸ This is especially the case in Books 20 and 21, where we find Constantius and Julian as fellow Augusti being compared in grand fashion as they first negotiate with and then race to confront one another in a civil war. Yet there has been no study of the representation of Constantius and Julian as military commanders in Ammianus' Books 14–19. As the title of this article suggests, I focus on the representation of Constantius and Julian as commanders here, and on what that representation tells us about the historical “reality.” This is an important desideratum because the rhetorical skill that Ammianus employs to advance his own biases and perspective is nowhere more evident,⁹ in my view, than in his descriptions of the frontier policy of each emperor, in particular that on the Rhine and Danube, which constitutes a chief stage for Constantius and Julian's presentation in the *Res Gestae*. Indeed, as Guzmán Armario points out, “the frontier” served to legitimize emperors, and so their activities there formed vital criteria by which they were judged.¹⁰ If we bear in mind that Ammianus favors Julian over Constantius, or better put, Ammianus' objectivity towards Constantius “brilla por su ausencia,”¹¹ it is here, in his portrayal of Constantius and Julian on the northern frontiers, perhaps his most subtle comparison of all, that the historian uses his rhetorical skill not only to convey his preference for Julian, but also to outline key differences in imperial policy between the two commanders. These key differences are particularly evident in the *adlocutiones* or formal speeches to assemblies of soldiers that Ammianus assigns to each emperor in the context of frontier operations.¹² In two recent articles which focus on what he calls the “speech-scenes” in Ammianus, O'Brien has shown how these

⁶Guzmán Armario 2004.

⁷Barnes 1992, 1–2.

⁸Amm. 25.4.1: *Vir profecto heroicis connumerandus ingeniis*. See Fontaine 1978; Barnes 1998, 146–47, who discusses Ammianus' statement on Julian in chap. 13, “The New Achilles.”

⁹Cf. Blockley 1994, 62: “Ammianus is one of the most rhetorical of the ancient historians. His purpose in his writing is primarily that of a rhetorician: to persuade his listeners and readers to his point of view, often argued in his own person.”

¹⁰Guzmán Armario 2006a, esp. 38, 42–43, 54, 56, 57–59. See also Goffart 1981, esp. 280–81.

¹¹Guzmán Armario 2006b, 433.

¹²On the traditional *adlocutio* during the Principate, see Campbell 1984, 69–88.

scenes “isolate a vital moment of political discourse and afford a subtle mode of characterization.”¹³ He has also noted that “formal representation of speech encodes objective criteria of imperial legitimacy” and “serves as a yardstick for his [Ammianus’] assessment of subjective merit” (2013a, 226). As we shall see below, these observations find further support in a close reading of the unique language and setting that Ammianus uses to craft his characterizations of Constantius and Julian as commanders.

At 14.10.14, in the first “speech-scene” of the extant text, Ammianus has Constantius describe himself *ut cunctator et cautus utiliumque monitor* or “like one who is reluctant and cautious and an advisor of useful measures.”¹⁴ Does Ammianus mean this to be a positive portrayal? The description of Valentinian at 27.10.10 and the context in which it is made should make us think twice. In fact, after outlining the context of 14.10.14 and other descriptions and their intratextuality in the *Res Gestae*,¹⁵ I will argue that Ammianus actually means *ut cunctator et cautus* in an ironic and negative sense. This intratextual reading builds on the work of scholars who have seen the possibility of this characterization, such as Szidat, Sabbah, and Seager, particularly in the latter’s study of the caution of Valentinian at 27.10 in a similar military context.¹⁶ As Sharrock (2000, 5) defines it:

Reading intratextually means looking at the text from different directions (backwards as well as forwards), chopping it up in various ways, building it up again, contracting and expanding its boundaries both within the *opus* and outside it.

This will precisely be my method, with the ultimate aim of viewing the work as a unity so as to provide another perspective on the larger picture of the northern frontiers under Constantius and Julian in Ammianus’ text.¹⁷ In thinking about Ammianus intratextually, I am following Kelly (2008, 8), who has suggested, after studies of many “intra-textual features” such as cross-references and common themes in the History, that

¹³ O’Brien 2013a, 226; 2013b.

¹⁴ *Quam ut cunctator et cautus utiliumque monitor, si uestra uoluntas adest, tribui debere censeo multa contemplanis.*

¹⁵ On intratextuality, see Sharrock 2000.

¹⁶ Szidat 1972, esp. 718; Sabbah 1978, 187–90; Seager 1986, 74–75, for the occasionally negative meaning of *cautus*; O’Brien 2013a, 229–30 (O’Brien unfortunately overlooks the *ut*).

¹⁷ In relation to Constantius’ campaigns on the eastern frontier, Barnes 1998, 138, has pointed out that “Constantius’ achievement on the northern frontiers is far harder to assess.”

Ammianus' work "was conceived, written, and very probably published, as a unity."¹⁸ In fact, Kelly has observed that intratextual connections appear to be "an obsession" with Ammianus (214). And this obsession of method manifests itself alongside an obsession with the interplay between characters, of using Julian as an *exemplum* by which other emperors are judged.¹⁹ This is particularly the case with Julian and Constantius,²⁰ for Kelly (301–3) has shown a strong intratextual connection between the two emperors at 16.12.55–57 and 17.13.15, that is, at Argentoratum in 357 (Julian) and on the Danube in 358 (Constantius), respectively. And, as we shall see below, there are other cross-references and common themes and therefore further interplay between these two characters, among others.

In his assessment of how Ammianus sarcastically depicts Valentinian, Seager (1996, 191) notes that "Ammianus consistently praises caution and criticises rashness, not least in the military sphere."²¹ However, Ammianus does not always convey caution in a positive sense. A perception of caution or its antonym depends on the context of its use. Perhaps a better way to put it would be, "What kind of caution does Ammianus intend to convey at any given point?" since caution in a positive sense presupposes the existence of a negative sense as well, namely, timidity, which comes in for criticism from the historian along with rashness. Moreover, Ammianus' singular rendering of Julian as *bellicosus ductor* or "a warlike leader" at 16.12.18 supports this interpretation.²² Does Ammianus mean for both *cunctator* and *ductor* to be positive evaluations? Or, perhaps better stated, is one more positive than the other?²³

When we remember that "the frontier" served a legitimizing function for emperors, it would appear that Ammianus employs language with this function in mind and portrays one emperor as more martial and effective and so more legitimate than another. The distinct descriptions

¹⁸ Cf. Kulikowski 2012, for the possibility of Book 31 originally conceived and written as a standalone monograph. See also Frakes 1995; Barnes 1998, 213–17.

¹⁹ On Ammianus' contrasting of Julian to other emperors, see Kelly 2008, 299–317.

²⁰ Kelly 2008, 304: "This is because an account of Constantius' reign exists for comparison, and because Julian is both explicitly and implicitly contrasted to Constantius throughout their joint reign."

²¹ See also Seager 1986, 71–83.

²² In a brief speech by Julian's standard-bearer: *perge, felicissime omnium Caesar, quo te fortuna prosperior ducit. tandem per te uirtutem et consilia militare sentimus. praei nos ut faustus antesignanus et fortis! experieris, quid miles sub conspectu bellicosi ductoris testisque indiuidui gerendorum, modo adsit superum numen, uiribus efficiet excitatis.*

²³ Ammianus consistently uses *cunctator* as an adjective, as in *ut dux cunctator et tutus*, while he uses it as a noun in *ut antiquus ille Cunctator*. *Ductor* is consistently a noun.

of Constantius as “one who hesitates” (*cunctator*) and Julian as “one who leads” (*ductor*) are key ways in which Ammianus conveys the quality of generalship and the divergent frontier policies of each emperor in the *Res Gestae*: the former connotes a preference for avoiding pitched battles and staving off defeat, and thus a defensive-minded approach, while the latter suggests confronting Rome’s enemies and acquiring victory, and thus an offensive-minded one. Indeed, as Blockley has observed, these divergent policies of Constantius and Julian, of a preference for battle or its avoidance, are recognized by Libanius (*Or.* 18, 205–7),²⁴ albeit with reference to the eastern frontier. It may be that the use of *cunctator* always inescapably evoked Fabius Maximus among Roman readers, as it is certainly meant to in Ammianus’ description of Theodosius the Elder *ut antiquus ille Cunctator*; yet Ammianus uses *antiquus* with *Cunctator* only once in his extant History (and near the very end) to allude to Fabius, and so this direct comparison stands apart from his other uses of *cunctator*. This is instructive, for it points to a delineation within the text of *Cunctator* as direct historical *exemplum*, and *cunctator* as a contemporary descriptor of personal character and imperial policy. In fact, Ammianus’ use of the archaisms *cunctator* and *ductor* constitutes an adducing of epic diction when they are placed side by side, with an eye to highlighting by contrast Julian’s character, abilities, and preferences as a general.²⁵ But we should not look only at these two descriptions; we should also place large amounts of text (and other small portions) from which they emanate side by side.

It cannot be a coincidence that these two very different depictions of Constantius and Julian occur in the context of two very different *adlocutiones* to the Roman army during vital decision points, one recommending that the army accept peace in 354 C.E. and another exhorting the army to action in 357, and both against the Alamanni on the Rhine frontier.²⁶ While Ammianus has Constantius describe himself *ut cunctator*

²⁴ Blockley 1989, 465–66. In Libanius’ Funeral Oration, it is evident that Constantius’ avoidance of battle was “a central element in the emperor’s strategy” against the Persians (465), a strategy of which Libanius disapproved.

²⁵ Selem 1979, 147, for the use of the archaic *ductor* in order to better emphasize Julian’s military skill, especially when compared with *cunctator*. *Ductor* is a favorite word of Vergil’s in the *Aeneid*. See also Foucher 2000, 182.

²⁶ Interestingly, Ammianus renders *imperator pro tempore pauca dicturus . . . ad hunc disseruit modum* for Constantius (14.10.10; cf. O’Brien 2013a, 228), yet uses the verb *adloquitur* for Julian (16.12.8). This might indicate Ammianus’ preference for the speech of Julian, who recommends action, and antipathy for that of Constantius, who recommends peace. Indeed, Ammianus also uses *adloquitur* for Constantius just before he addresses Julian

et cautus, Julian, on the other hand, does not glorify himself as *bellicosus ductor*, but is praised as such by his own standard-bearer; it is through these subtleties, which have the effect of giving the statements greater authenticity, that Ammianus reinforces his judgments. And in this subtle comparison of Constantius with Julian we most vividly see an authorial intrusion which supports the frontier policy of the latter over the former: it appears that caution here is synonymous with timidity in the case of Constantius at 14.10.14, and so it is not praise that is meant, but censure; by contrast, the bellicose epithet used of Julian at 16.12.18 constitutes the highest approval and, therefore, the better policy in the eyes of the historian. In order to show this, I will focus on the three relevant speech-scenes and the contexts in which they are made: one by Constantius (14.10.11–15) on the Rhine in 354 and one by Julian (16.12.9–12) on the Rhine in 357 at Argentoratum, and another by Constantius (17.13.26–33) on the Danube in 358.

I

In the summer of 353 C.E., Constantius became sole Augustus and primary ruler of the Roman Empire upon defeating the usurper Magnentius at Mons Seleucus in Gaul. But Constantius had had help. In early 351, Constantius had elevated his cousin Gallus to Caesar in the East to help him guard the frontier there against the Persians while he dealt with Magnentius, a task which the Caesar appears to have taken up capably.²⁷

directly during his investiture (15.8.11). Note also that Ammianus prefaces Constantius' speech at 17.13.26–33 (which comes after a successful engagement against the Sarmatians on the Danube and so reads like a kind of after action report) with *Constantius . . . adlocutus est* (17.13.25).

²⁷Lib. *Or.* 18, 16; Amm. 14.2.20, for Gallus' authority over the *comes Orientis* Nebridius and successful military response to the depredating Isaurians. 14.7.5: *Gallus Hierapolim profecturus, ut expeditioni specie tenus adesset* (cf. 21.13.8, for Constantius' use of Hierapolis as a base when dealing with the Persians, and 23.2.6, for Julian's use of Hierapolis as a forward operating base for his Persian campaign). 14.9.1, for his appointment of Ursicinus as chief judge in a treason trial at Antioch; Zos. 3.1.1: Πέρσας δὲ τοῦ τὴν ἑφάν παρενοχλεῖν οὐκ ἀφίσταμένους, εἰ καὶ πρότερον ἡσύχαζον δέει τοῦ μὴ τὸν Καίσαρα Γάλλον αὐτοῖς ἐπελθεῖν; Jer. *Chron.* s. a. 352, Soc. *HE* 2.33, Soz. *HE* 4.7.5, for Gallus' dispatching of a military force to suppress a Jewish revolt at Diocaesarea. See Thompson 1943, esp. 303–4; 1969, 56–71; Blockley 1972, esp. 441–43, 455–68. While the events recorded above by Ammianus date to late 353/early 354 (see Barnes 1989), it may very well be that Gallus displayed similar energy and authority during the entirety of his three years as Caesar. Note that Ammianus casually mentions these events, which perhaps implies that they were not anomalous acts.

After eventually bringing this civil war to a close in 353, Constantius remained on the Upper Rhine in Gaul to consolidate his authority there and deal with incursions of the Alamanni, incursions which had probably been orchestrated by Constantius himself so as to divide Magnentius' attention and resources.²⁸ In the spring of 354, Constantius left Arelate (Arles) for a projected punitive campaign across the Rhine against the Alamanni in response to frequent raids by the "kings" and brothers Gundomadus and Vadomarius (14.10.1).²⁹ Ultimately, the operation was shut down near Augusta Rauracorum (Kaiseraugst) without any fighting as Constantius was confounded and uncertain about how to respond (*imperator cogitationibus magnis attonitus, quid capesseret, ambigebat*, 14.10.6)³⁰ to Alamannic opposition to a planned Roman pontoon bridge. "After thinking the matter over for some time rather secretly" (*negotio tectius diu pensato*, 10.10), a statement which emphasizes Constantius' uncertainty and reluctance at 10.6, the emperor via an *adlocutio* (10.11–15) moved the Romans to accept an offer of peace from the two brothers

Of course, Constantius also had left behind capable generals, like Ursicinus, whom he could rely on for most of the campaigning in the East.

²⁸Lib. *Or.* 18, 33–36; Soc. 3.1.26; Soz. 5.1.2, 5.2.20; Zos. 2.53.3; Bowersock 1978, 33; Drinkwater 2007, 165, 176, 201–2. Cf. Jul. *Or.* 1, 12A–B, for Constantius having learned from Constantine how to instigate the barbarian tribes to his advantage. See also Jul. *Ep. ad Athen.* 286A; Claud. Mamert. 6.1; Lib. *Or.* 13, 35; *Or.* 18, 107, 113; Amm. 21.3.4–5, for Constantius' later use of Vadomarius and the Alamanni to keep Julian occupied on the Rhine in 360/1.

²⁹PLRE 1.928, Vadomarius. See Pighi 1936, 3–19. For Ammianus and Vadomarius, see Woods 2000. Woods speculates much here and to my mind does not convincingly answer this key question: why would Julian, who arrested Vadomarius and sent him to Spain in 361 for having acted either on Constantius' behalf or his own, subsequently make a complete turnaround and promote this man to *dux Phoenices*? Simply put, what had Vadomarius done for Julian to merit such an appointment? More likely, Vadomarius was promoted by Jovian in 363/4 or Valentinian and Valens in 364/5. Interestingly, Ammianus alludes to an *agens in rebus* when describing Vadomarius as *dux Phoenices* (21.3.5: *Vadomarius haec et similia perpetrabat ad perstringendum fallendumque miris modis ab aetatis primitiis callens, ut postea quoque ducatum per Phoenicem regens ostendit*. Cf. 16.9.2: *per emissarios quosdam fallendi perstringendique gnaros*). For the possible identity of these "emissaries" as *agentes*, see Austin and Rankov 1998, 20, 232–33), which is consistent with Vadomarius' overall portrayal here as an *agens Constantii* charged with stymying Julian.

³⁰Cf. Amm. 21.7.1, where Constantius is described in identical language (*quid capesseret, ambigebat*), uncertain as he was whether to confront Julian or the Persian King Shapur II. Ammianus employs this expression two more times in the History: first, in the case of the praetorian prefect Petronius Probus (*quid capesseret, ambigens*, 29.6.9), who did not know how to respond to the raids of the Quadi and Sarmatians on the Danube; and second, in the case of the Alamannic Lentienses as a group when dealing with Gratian on the Rhine (*quid capesserent, ambigentes*, 31.10.12).

(10.9–10) and retired to Mediolanum (Milan) by October 354.³¹ That the emperor had made an attempt to ford the Rhine shows that he wanted to deal with the Alamanni in their own territory.

Yet how far into Alamannia did Constantius want to penetrate? This question has occasioned a reevaluation of Valentinian's intentions on the Rhine after 367.³² As for Constantius, his campaigns show that he did not stray far from the enemy bank of the Rhine, or later, the Danube. Foiled in his bridge building attempt in 354, Constantius remained stationary, as did the Alamanni, until finally the latter blinked first and asked Constantius for peace, proposing terms which he found acceptable and presented to the Roman army (*pacem oportere tribui, quae iustis condicionibus petebatur*, 10.10; [*pacem*] *tribui debere censeo multa contemplans*, 10.14). This Alamannic proposal, we are told, was due either to unfavorable auspices or to the judgment of their religious rites, which prohibited an engagement and so diminished their ardor for war (*dirimentibus forte auspiciis uel congregi prohibente auctoritate sacrorum mollito rigore, quo fidentius resistebant*, 10.9),³³ meaning that the Alamanni would otherwise have continued their opposition. This is significant, for a Roman reading this might have expected to learn next that Constantius attacked an enfeebled Alamanni, only to be disappointed that *ut cunctator et cautus* is what follows; thus, the self-description recoils upon the emperor. After considering the options, Constantius ratified the peace; clearly, had he been firmly committed to punishing the Alamanni for their recent mischief, the emperor would have rejected the offer of peace terms and found a way to cross the Rhine and attack them, especially in light of their *mollito rigore*. To be sure, Constantius had the time, as it does not appear that he had any other pressing problems in late 354;

³¹When discussing the events of 356 (16.12.15–17), Ammianus mentions that two royal brothers of the Alamanni obtained peace from Constantius in the previous year (*regii duo fratres uinculo pacis astricti, quam anno praeterito impetrauerant a Constantio*, 16.12.17). These two brothers were Gundomadus and Vadomarius (21.3.4). If nothing else, Constantius was a patient man who had already waited for some time for the supplies needed to fuel the campaign in early 354 (14.10.2); it is not unlikely that the two armies, locked in a stalemate, encamped where they were during the summer until a resolution was finally reached in late 354, for Constantius was at Milan during the execution of Gallus Caesar (14.10.16: *imperator Mediolanum ad hiberna discessit*; cf. 14.11.5–23) and is attested there on 1 January 355 (*CTH* 11.34.2). For the dating of Gallus' death to October, see Barnes 1989, 413–16.

³²Drinkwater 1999, esp. 128. For a more recent and interdisciplinary study of the Alamanni and Rome, see Drinkwater 2007.

³³See Seager 1999, 580, who observes that the seeking of peace by the Alamanni "reflects no credit on Constantius," precisely because of this language.

Magnentius had been defeated in the prior year (14.1.1), Gallus Caesar was then being dealt with in the East (14.11), and the Persians would not cause any serious trouble until 359–60, when they would boldly invade Mesopotamia (18.7–19.9, 20.6–7, 20.11, 21.7, 21.13).

This may be the very point that Ammianus means to communicate, for there is an intertextual allusion in play here. Viansino (2004, 127) traced Ammianus' use of *cunctator et cautus* back to Tacitus, but the allusion itself has been overlooked. The allusion is noteworthy because Ammianus renders Constantius in a fashion similar to how Tacitus describes the general Suetonius Paulinus, who fought for Otho during the civil war of 69 C.E.: "a reluctant man by nature and for whom cautious plans with consideration seemed right rather than success due to chance" (*cunctator natura et cui cauta potius consilia cum ratione quam prospera ex casu placerent*, *Hist.* 2.25.2).³⁴ Paulinus eventually engaged the Vitellians, yet stopped short once they were on the run. Tacitus relates that it was commonly understood that Paulinus could have destroyed the opposing Vitellian general Caecina Alienus and his force if Paulinus had not ordered a retreat, which was enjoined because Paulinus feared the great effort necessary for pursuit and that his soldiers might be counterattacked while fatigued and left with no hope of escape (2.26.2).³⁵ It is by rendering Paulinus *cunctator natura* that Tacitus conveys the general's character. Ammianus apparently adapted this passage for his own purposes when rendering Constantius and crafting his speech (14.10.11–15). Indeed, as Blockley (1973, 74) has noted regarding *adlocutiones* in Ammianus, and Constantius' one here in particular:

one function of the speeches may perhaps be characterized as Tacitean. They are sometimes used by Ammianus to illustrate the discrepancies between words and facts, to set forth the fine claims of the speakers which conflict with the reality described in the narrative.

³⁴This is consistent with Tacitus' description of Paulinus elsewhere: *Suetonio Paulino, diligenti ac moderato duci* (*Agr.* 5.1). Perhaps Tacitus drew some inspiration for his depiction at 2.25.2 from Livy, who relates a similar preference in Fabius Cunctator's advice to his military subordinate, *ut plus consilio quam fortunae confidat* (22.18.9). While *cunctator* seemingly evokes Fabius in Tacitus, it may also reflect a different usage and so my rendering of "reluctant." See also Ash 2007, 146.

³⁵*ceterum ea ubique formido fuit apud fugientes occurrentes, in acie pro uallo, ut deleri cum uniuerso exercitu Caecinam potuisse, ni Suetonius Paulinus receptui cecinisset, utrisque in partibus percrebruerat. timuisse se Paulinus ferebat tantum insuper laboris atque itineris, ne Vitellianus miles recens e castris fessos adgrederetur et perculsis nullum retro subsidium foret.* The text used here is that of Heubner's 1978 critical edition. Cf. Foucher 2000, 415–16;

While Constantius suspended operations against the Alamanni because, he initially states, they asked for peace from a growing respect for Roman arms and a sense of fear (14.10.14),³⁶ he subsequently undermines this claim by relating his primary concern that “the uncertainties of battle should be avoided” (*primo ut Martis ambigua declinentur*, 10.14), a comment which evokes Paulinus’ preference for “cautious plans with consideration rather than success due to chance” (*cauta potius consilia cum ratione quam prospera ex casu*). That Constantius did not continue the campaign points to the strong possibility that his efforts to build a pontoon bridge were specifically geared to avoid battle and achieve a negotiated settlement all along,³⁷ for he is consistently depicted by Ammianus as hesitant to engage the Alamanni.

Interestingly, Ammianus has Constantius tell the assembled soldiers, right at the start of his *adlocutio*, that he had been “marching on the foreign villages with confidence in you [the soldiers] leading the way” (*fiducia uestri ductante barbaricos pagos aduentans*, 10.11), but then declares that he had something like a sudden change of heart that moved him to milder measures (*uelut mutato repente consilio ad placidiora deuerti*). What, exactly, had moved Constantius to change his plan? He subsequently tells us that he is inclined to accept the Alamannic proposal chiefly because of the uncertainty of success in battle (*primo ut Martis ambigua declinentur*, 10.14), but also because he believes that, in place of adversaries, Rome will receive new recruits for the army, which were promised (*dein ut auxiliores pro aduersariis asciscamus, quod pollicentur*), that such a measure will save Roman manpower and spare the provinces (*tum autem ut incruenti mitigemus ferociae flatus perniciosos saepe prouinciis*), and finally, so that he who has been tested will perceive that (the Romans) lack neither bravery against rebels nor leniency against suppliants (*postremo . . . qui sentit expertus nec fortitudinem in rebelles*

Ash 2007, 148–49. See also Pighi 1936, 113; Sabbah 1978, 15–17; Barnes 1998, 194–95, for Ammianus’ use of Tacitus’ *Histories*.

³⁶ *arduos uestrae gloriae gradus, quos fama per plagarum quoque accolae extimarum diffundit excellenter accrescens, Alamannorum reges et populi formidantes per oratores, quos uidetis, summissis ceruicibus concessionem praeteritorum poscunt et pacem.*

³⁷ Ammianus relates the story that a knowledgeable guide, who knew of an alternative crossing point, surprisingly (*ecce autem ex improviso*) came forward to tell the Romans about it for a price, but that this was soon after disclosed to the Alamanni by some of their fellows who held high rank in the Roman army and so prevented a Roman crossing (14.10.7). Nevertheless, Ammianus seems to have doubts about this story, as his use of *ut quidam existimabant* reveals. Cf. Seager 1999, 580, n. 2.

nec lenitatem in supplices animos abesse). These last three points that Constantius presents in favor of accepting peace—future Roman recruits, preservation of Roman manpower and provinces, and proliferation of the Roman reputation for evenhandedness—contribute to the ironic portrayal here when we consider that about one year later (in the next book, Book 15) Constantius would be elevating Julian to the Caesarship in late 355 precisely because these promises had proved futile as Gaul was then being overrun, albeit by other Alamanni (15.4.1, 15.8.1).

Yet the uncertainty of success in battle, the primary reason (*primo*), comes on the heels of Constantius describing himself *ut cunctator et cautus utiliumque monitor* (14.10.14), which he buttresses further by then remarking that he is “like a peaceful prince” (*ut princeps tranquillus*, 10.15) and speaking of “restraint and humanity” (*modestiae humanitatieque*).³⁸ The tone of this *adlocutio* is less than martial; Ammianus is anchoring Constantius’ caution to his lack of confidence in battle. It is at this point, right at the conclusion of the *adlocutio*, that Ammianus cleverly presents Constantius’ less than sterling reputation in foreign wars as a subsidiary concern behind the army’s assent to Constantius’ proposal for peace (10.16);³⁹ this serves to underscore his uncertainty of success in battle and his relative ineffectiveness as a general.⁴⁰ Indeed, Ammianus is particularly interested in *efficacia* or “effectiveness,” a trait he occasionally ascribes

³⁸ Cf. Eutrop. 10.15.2: *uir egregiae tranquillitatis*. See also Seager 1986, 1, 20; O’Brien 2013a, 231, who sees *modestia* and *humanitas* as words that carry “definite negative overtones and may be read in an ironic light.” This becomes a certainty when we consider that they are tethered to *ut cunctator et cautus utiliumque monitor*; cf. O’Brien 2013a, 249. Note also that in his final *adlocutio* at 21.13.10–15, Constantius styles himself *utque cautus nauigandi magister* (21.13.10) and in the same breath speaks of his *humanitas*. This is typical of “Constantinian rhetoric,” the exception being the speech at 17.13.26–33. Moreover, as Seager 1986, 20, has observed, *humanitas* in Ammianus “is often feigned or abused.”

³⁹ See Amm. 14.11.8, 21.16.15, where this is further emphasized. Cf. Lib. *Or.* 59, 76, 81, 88, 96; *Or.* 18, 205–7; Eutrop. 10.10.1: *Diuersa Constantii fortuna fuit*. 10.15.2: *in ciuilibus magis quam in externis bellis sit laudanda fortuna*; Fest. 27.1: *Constantius in Persas uario ac magis difficili pugnauit euentu*; Epit. 42.18: *Felix bellis ciuilibus, externis lacrimabilis*. For a more nuanced view, see Blockley 1989, 465–67, 472–73, 488. See also Szidat 1996, 219–21. Note that Aurelius Victor, writing *ca.* 360/1 while Constantius was still alive, has little to say about Constantius’ achievements in foreign wars (*sustentatoque interim Persarum impetu genti Sarmatarum magno decore considens apud eos regem dedit*, 42.21), whereas Eutropius and Festus, writing safely after Constantius, have much more to say.

⁴⁰ Cf. O’Brien 2013a, 228: “Ammianus’ editorial intrusion . . . casts doubt on the autonomy and persuasiveness of Constantius as an orator, not to mention on his standing as a capable general.”

to various figures.⁴¹ But Constantius is not among them; the closest the emperor gets to such *efficacia* is when he praises the *efficacia ducum* (17.13.27), that is, his generals, in an *adlocutio* to his assembled troops on the Danube (see below). Constantius' declaration of praise has the effect of having him relinquish military effectiveness to his subordinates. Thus, it is all the more noteworthy when we see Julian described in superlative fashion as *efficacissimus Caesar* (16.4.4).

The fact that Constantius lacked a measure of confidence in battle with a foreign foe, then, helps to explain and support his caution, or timidity, *ut cunctator et cautus* at 14.10.14. The consistent use of such an *ut* here and elsewhere (as in the case of Valentinian at 27.10.10) is suggestive: it may represent a clear marker of Ammianus' thinking, whereby *ut* ("like" or "as") wryly signifies "similar to, but not quite."⁴² Furthermore,

⁴¹ Amm. 14.8.5: *Nicator Seleucus . . . efficaciae impetrabilis rex*. 15.5.2: *Silvanus pedestris militiae rector ut efficax ad haec corrigenda*. 16.4.4: *efficacissimus Caesar* (Julian). 19.5.3: *efficacia eorum eminuit* (two Gallic legions formerly under Magnentius and stationed at Amida). 19.9.2: *Aeliano comite et tribunis, quorum efficacia diu defensa sunt moenia stragesque multiplicatae Persarum*. 21.3.4: *Constantius . . . existimans fidum secretorumque taciturnum exsecutorem et efficacem mandabat* (Vadomarius). 27.8.6: *dux efficacissimus* (Theodosius the Elder). 28.1.52: *quemnam potissimum exsecutorem atrocis rei fidum inueniret et efficacem* (the wording alludes to Vadomarius and his services for Constantius at 21.3.4). 31.6.5: *quem cogitatorum norant fore socium efficacem* (Fritigern). 31.16.8: *efficacia Iulii magistri militiae trans Taurum enituit salutaris et uelox*. These last two usages of *efficax* and *efficacia* in Book 31 show that there were men on both sides, Roman and Goth, who were effective generals with the exception of Valens.

⁴² Ammianus often uses an *ut* to introduce a simile or comparison that conveys the poor or flawed character or circumstances of certain figures in the *Res Gestae*. Cf. Amm. 14.7.13: *Gallus ut serpens appetitus telo uel saxo iamque spes extremas opperiens*. 14.9.9: *ferociens Gallus ut leo cadaueribus pastus multa huiusmodi scrutabatur*. 16.8.10: *Constantius impendio timidus . . . semper se ferri sperabat, ut Dionysius tyrannus ille Siciliae*. 18.4.4: *qui ut coluber copia uirus exuberans natorum multitudinem etiamtum aegre serpentium excitans ad nocendum* (Constantius' *praepositus cubiculi* Eusebius). 19.3.3: *ut leo magnitudine corporis et toruitate terribilis inclusos intra retia catulos periculo ereptum ire non audens unguibus adeptis et dentibus* (Ursicinus, who was constrained by Sabinianus). Note also *Ingressus itaque Parisios Leonas susceptus ut honoratus et prudens* at 20.9.6. When we consider that Leonas came to Paris after Julian's pronouncement to implement Constantius' demands, one of which was that Julian revert to the rank of Caesar, it may very well be that Ammianus is being sarcastic here. And at 15.5.2 Ammianus tells us *Silvanus pedestris militiae rector ut efficax ad haec corrigenda*, which appears to be qualified by the *ut*, perhaps so that Silvanus cannot compete later with Julian, who will truly "correct" and restore Gaul as *efficacissimus Caesar* (16.4.4). See also Thompson 1943, 315, for his observation about *Gallus ut leo cadaueribus pastus multa huiusmodi scrutabatur* at 14.9.9: "The difference in intensity between the simile and the verb illustrates the historian's rhetorical methods."

Ammianus frequently employs the verb *ambigere* and the adjective *ambiguus* in a military context with Constantius in order to describe as uncertain either the emperor's mindset or the circumstances in which he is involved, a description which serves doubly to testify to Constantius' shaky confidence in the field when compared with Julian's.⁴³ Whereas the former at times was uncertain about how to respond to a military situation, the latter was almost always certain.⁴⁴

Not long after his promotion to Caesar in late 355, Julian became a confident and capable general in Gaul, one with sufficient challenges to test him in the incursions of the Franks and Alamanni, the kind of incursions which had prompted Constantius to grant him the title of Caesar in the first place. Like his half-brother Gallus before him, Julian's authority as Caesar was narrowly limited to the military sphere, and even that was prudently restricted at first.⁴⁵ But Julian would display feats of daring in the field, both in Gaul and later in Persia, in contrast to Constantius' caution. To answer why these two men were so different in their approaches would require us to know the unknowable, namely, what each was thinking when he made an important military decision. However, Ammianus provides us with a hint of his answer when he presents the point of view of some of Julian's detractors (*obtrectatoribus*), who supposed (*fingentibus*) that Julian was consistently daring because he preferred to die gloriously in

⁴³ Amm. 14.10.6: *quid capesseret, ambigebat*. 14.10.14: *primo ut Martis ambigua declinentur* (against the Alamanni). 17.6.1: *Inter quae ita ambigua* (while dealing with the Persians). 19.11.1: *Inter haec ita ambigua [Constantium]* (against the Limigantes). 20.9.3: *Perculsus tamen ardentem cunctatione stringebatur ambigua* (whether to attack the Persians or Julian). 21.7.1: *quid capesseret, ambigebat*. 21.13.2: *uerum consiliorum ambiguum retinebant multiplices morae*. 21.13.9: *Summa itaque coeptorum quorsum euaderet, ambigens*. Cf. de Jonge 1982, 201, for the formulaic expressions at 17.6.1 and 19.11.1 used to denote uncertainty on the frontier. See also den Boeft et al. 1987, 223, for Ammianus conveying "the impression that Constantius was lacking in resolve."

⁴⁴ Cf. Amm. 21.1.1: *semperque ambigens, utrum Constantium modis omnibus alliceret in concordiam an terroris incutiendi gratia lacesseret prior*. This does not reflect Julian's military uncertainty, but whether his negotiations with Constantius would prove worthwhile. 22.1.1: *sed responsis ambiguis et obscuris haerebat futurorum incertus*. Here, Julian doubts, not his military skill, but whether the will of divine providence, which trumps all, would favor his cause against Constantius or not. 24.8.7: *ideo inter haec ita ambigua*. This is the sole instance where Ammianus applies this formulaic expression to Julian, which is done in a military context and underscores the fact that Julian's confidence and planning had gone astray in Persia.

⁴⁵ Jul. *Ep. ad Athen.* 277D–78D; Lib. *Or.* 18, 42, 84; Amm. 15.8.13. 21.13.13: *Iulianus, quem, dum circumfremantes Illyricum nationes exteris oppugnatis, tuendis praefecimus Galliis*. 25.4.25: *specie Caesaris missus*; Zos. 3.2.2. See also Blockley 1972, 446–48, 452–53.

battle rather than to die, as they anticipated (*sicut sperabant*),⁴⁶ in the manner of criminals like his brother Gallus.⁴⁷ The historian himself does not believe this, as his use of *fingentibus* shows. Moreover, this statement is followed by Ammianus with the rebuttal that Julian continued to be daring even after Constantius died (*ni pari proposito post excessum quoque Constanti actibus mirandis inclaruisset*, 17.1.14). In short, Julian was a daring commander because it was a part of his nature; by implication, Constantius was by nature a cautious commander, like Suetonius Paulinus. According to Ammianus, Julian was “very similar to Trajan in the glorious course of his wars” (*bellorum gloriosis cursibus Traiani simillimus*, 16.1.4).⁴⁸ Be that as it may, Julian’s initial *exemplum* as Caesar was evidently his cousin Constans, who had campaigned actively on the Rhine against the Franks and Alamanni in the early 340s.⁴⁹ In any event, it is clear that each commander prosecuted war and responded to military problems in the manner that seemed best to him.

In 357, during Julian’s second year in Gaul, the Alamanni once again crossed the Rhine, this time while Julian was engaged in repairing the fortification at Tres Tabernae (Saverne, 16.12.1, cf. 16.11.11). The confrontation to come would be the first big test of Julian’s effectiveness, both as a general and an orator. In a minor *adlocutio* (16.12.9–12) before the battle of Argentoratum (Strasbourg) that same year,⁵⁰ Julian speaks to his

⁴⁶ Both Clark 1963 and Seyfarth 1999 opted for *sperabat*, that is, Julian; but earlier editors (*BAG*) have *sperabant*, referring to the detractors, which might make more sense in terms of contrasting the two: *optabat* . . . *sperabant*. Indeed, if Ammianus meant *sperabat*, then it seems to me that he would (or should) have used an *ipse* so as to distinguish Julian from the detractors and the impersonal subject of *potuit* at 17.1.14 (cf. 18.3.2: *ipse, ut sperabat*; 29.2.7: *sicut ipse uoluit*). Furthermore, *optabat* is presented here as the view of the detractors, not that of Julian himself.

⁴⁷ 17.1.14: *credique obtrectatoribus potuit ideo fortiter eum ubique fecisse fingentibus, quod oppetere dimicando gloriose magis optabat quam damnatorum sorte, sicut sperabant, ut frater Gallus occidi*.

⁴⁸ See also Amm. 17.1.11, where Julian is again connected to Trajan as a commander through his repairing of a Trajanic fortification across the Rhine, which highlights his plan of reconquest.

⁴⁹ Lib. *Or.* 59, 127; Jul. *Or.* 1, 9D; Aur. Vict. *Caes.* 41.23; Eutrop. 10.9.4; Amm. 20.1.1, 30.7.5; Jer. s. a. 341, 342. In addition to Julian’s knowledge of Constans’ campaigns in a general sense (*Or.* 1, 9D), it is significant that his *praepositus cubiculi* in Gaul was Eutherius, who had formerly served Constans and likely shared his knowledge of Constans and his policies with Julian (Amm. 16.7.5–6).

⁵⁰ Cf. O’Brien 2013b, 148–49, for Julian’s speech as a *cohortatio*. An *adlocutio* was the strict prerogative of an Augustus, but Ammianus specifically uses *adloquitur* for this speech (16.12.8) just as he does for that of Constantius during Julian’s investiture (15.8.11), and so my description of Julian’s here as a minor *adlocutio*. See also Pighi 1936, esp. 104–12.

soldiers of choosing a “more cautious path” (*cautiores uiam*, 16.12.9) and of being “controlled and reflective” (*regibilem et consultam*, 12.10).⁵¹ This comes on the heels of Ammianus’ initially describing Julian as “deliberating rightly for advantage and security” (*utilitati securitatis recte consulens Caesar*, 12.8). In keeping with this characterization, Julian goes on to suggest a nearly one-day delay so that the fatigued Romans can recover their strength before engaging the Alamanni (12.11–12), which appears to be an instance of reverse psychology on Julian’s part and meant to inspire the Romans actually to fight then and there.⁵² Indeed, Ammianus tells us that the soldiers were so energized by Julian’s words that they did not even let him finish (*Nec finire perpersi, quae dicebantur*, 12.13). At 16.12.9, before speaking of *cautiores uiam*, Julian does not describe himself or the state of affairs in the same way that Constantius does at 14.10.11, instead addressing his troops as “my comrades in arms” (*commilitones mei*) and immediately thereafter promoting their “seasoned and robust valor” (*adulta robustaque uirtute*, 16.12.9). By referring to his soldiers as *commilitones mei* and referencing their *adulta robustaque uirtute* right at the outset of the speech, Julian thus immediately connects with his audience and points to his true intentions.⁵³ He subsequently concludes his speech by exhorting the legions to action (*triumphaturas aquilas et uexilla uictricia primo lucis moueamus exordio*, 12.12). Unlike Constantius, Julian makes no mention of a concern over “the uncertainties of battle.”

⁵¹These words must reflect Julian’s concern over having a smaller force than the Alamanni (cf. 16.12.6).

⁵²Cf. O’Brien 2013b, 152–54, who sees the speech as a “persuasive failure” (154). However, if we view the speech as cleverly designed to produce the opposite outcome of delay, then this makes better sense in keeping with O’Brien’s own observation that it “plays a significant part in Ammianus’ strategy of building Julian up for imperial office” (140). Julian knows what to say, how to say it, and when so as to produce a desired result; he invokes cautiousness and reflection, but in fact wants to fight immediately and leads his soldiers and the high command to this view. Indeed, this is in contrast to Constantius’ “persuasiveness” as an orator at 14.10.11–15 (cf. n. 40). Thus, I actually see Julian’s speech as a persuasive success. O’Brien doubts this view of reverse psychology being at play here because it “is not consistent with Ammianus’ characterization of Julian” (2013b, 154, n. 29). But we should consider his pronouncement at Paris, when Julian displays *recusatio imperii* in a very short speech (20.4.15–16). This would be entirely consistent with Julian’s speech at Argenteratum; Julian wanted to prove himself as a general but did not want to appear overly eager to do so. See also Bowersock 1978, 47–54; Matthews 2007, 91–92.

⁵³Note Julian’s *adlocutio* (21.5.2–8) in early 361, where he addresses his troops as *magni commilitones* (21.5.2) and speaks of *uirtutis uestrae* (21.5.3), once again at the start of the speech, and convinces them to march against Constantius; conversely, that of Constantius, who refers to his troops as *commilitones mei* in the middle of his speech (14.10.13) and without any reference to their *uirtus*.

In fact, before calling Julian *bellicosus ductor* (12.18), in what is a kind of reverse *adlocutio* by a soldier, the standard-bearer (*signifer*) first relates that the army finally has valor and plans in the field in the person of Julian and exhorts him in turn to lead the way as the foremost fighter who is lucky and brave (*tandem per te uirtutem et consilia militare sentimus. praei nos ut faustus antesignanus et fortis!*).⁵⁴ This is in contrast to Constantius, who, as we recall, briefly relates his confidence in his soldiers (*fiducia uestri ductante barbaricos pagos aduentans*, 14.10.11), but not the other way around as Julian's standard-bearer does here. Julian's soldiers consider their Caesar a fellow soldier, and it is evident here that the *protector domesticus* Ammianus shares this sentiment, for Julian's *adlocutio* displays a robust martial tone highlighted by *bellicosus ductor*. Indeed, Ammianus' careful language and setup further serve to foreshadow and underscore Julian's martial quality and effectiveness against the Alamanni at Argentoratum (cf. *efficacissimus Caesar*, 16.4.4), language which is markedly absent from Ammianus' description of Constantius' campaign of 354.

This is not surprising, for Ammianus prefaces the very start of Book 16 with Julian's "valor and good luck" (*uirtute felicitateque*, 16.1.2),⁵⁵ both of which are essential for a great commander, a reference that Constantius does not receive in Book 14. Instead, Ammianus sets an altogether different tone at the start of Book 14 with "raging storms of Fortune" (*Fortunae saeuientes procellae*, 14.1.1),⁵⁶ that is, the terrible activities under Gallus Caesar.⁵⁷ And later, Ammianus again emphasizes Julian's good luck when he tells us that Julian "thoughtlessly committed himself to uncertain fortune" (*temere se fortunae commisit ambiguae*, 21.5.13, cf. 26.5.11) when about to march into Pannonia against Constantius in early

⁵⁴ Cf. Amm. 16.12.13: *fortunati rectoris expertis uirtutibus freti* (Julian's soldiers); O'Brien 2013b, 155–60. See also de Jonge 1972b, 203, for *tandem* and *et consilia* representing "sneers at Constantius," and 204, for an analysis of *antesignanus*. Note that Julian is addressed as *felicitissime omnium* by his *signifer* at 16.12.18. And at 17.1.14 we again see *faustus* applied to Julian (*ut faustus Caesar exsultabat et felix*), who is the sole emperor in the extant books of the *Res Gestae* to be so described (see also 15.8.21: *imperatorem clementem appellans et faustum*). The only other figure who gets *faustus* is Arbitio (21.13.16: *Arbitionem ante alios faustum ad intestina bella sedanda*).

⁵⁵ Cf. Selem 1979, 130.

⁵⁶ In support of reading *saeuientes procellae*, note *magnitudo furentium incubuit procellarum* at 17.7.3.

⁵⁷ These "raging storms of Fortune" appear to have carried over into Constantius' campaign at 14.10, where we find Gallus invoked by name (14.10.1–2) and referred to through his maternal uncle, then the praetorian prefect of Gaul, Vulcacius Rufinus (Amm. 14.10.5; *PLRE* 1.782–83, Vulcacius Rufinus 25), who, we are told, was the target of a plot.

361.⁵⁸ Key elements of Julian's *adlocutio* and the army's reaction to it are in sharp contrast to those elements of Constantius' speech and the response of his own army which was content to accept a recommendation of peace. Moreover, Julian faced a very confident Alamanni at Argentoratum (*erexit autem confidentiam caput altius attollentium*, 16.12.2; cf. *mollito rigore*, 14.10.9); and following the victory on the Roman bank, he pressed his advantage by crossing the Rhine via a pontoon bridge and continuing the campaign (17.1.2).

It was after achieving his military objectives that Julian then engaged in diplomacy (17.1.12). This contrast between Constantius and Julian is further sharpened when Ammianus has Julian himself tell us later in another *adlocutio* (21.5.2–8), this one on the eve of his preemptive march against Constantius, that “In peacetime, I have appeared moderate and peaceful, and in the frequency of wars against the combined forces of foreign nations, deliberate and cautious” (*domi moderatus uisus sum et tranquilluss et in crebritate bellorum contra conspiratas gentium copias consideratus et cautus*, 21.5.5).⁵⁹ In the first self-description, that of “moderate and peaceful,” we see that it is squarely qualified by “peacetime” (*domi*), as opposed to the case of Constantius, whose earlier self-descriptions—*ut cunctator et cautus* (14.10.14) and *ut princeps tranquillus* (14.10.15) also in an *adlocutio*—we should note both occur while he is already engulfed in conflict with the Alamanni. In Julian's second self-description, that of “deliberate and cautious,” we do find that, like Constantius *ut cunctator et cautus*, it is made in the context of war (*bellorum*); but more importantly, unlike the descriptions of Constantius, neither *moderatus et tranquilluss* nor *consideratus et cautus* have a preceding *ut*, the importance of which will be further discussed below. It is apparent from his abortive campaign

⁵⁸ See also den Boeft et al. 1991, 73; Szidat 1996, 47. Since Ammianus begins 21.5.13 positively with *his Iulianus, ut poscebat negotii magnitudo*, it seems right to take his subsequent use of *temere* in a positive sense as well. Indeed, Ammianus is foreshadowing Julian's successful *aduentus* at Sirmium.

⁵⁹ Note that Ammianus has already described Julian as a “moderate ruler” in the previous book (*moderato rectore*, 20.4.13) and so he again highlights the new state of peace in Gaul here. As for *consideratus et cautus*, these words evoke what Constantius is made to say in his *adlocutio* at 15.8.13 during Julian's investiture in late 355 (*et si hostilibus congregi sit necesse, fixo gradu consiste inter signiferos ipsos, audendi in tempore consideratus hortator pugnantes accendens praeuendo cautissime turbatosque subsidiis fulciens modesteque increpans desides, uerissimus testis affuturus industriis et ignauis*), and therefore are deployed by Ammianus here as a kind of *apologia*, to show that Julian as Caesar had only acted in accordance with Constantius' instructions.

at 14.10 that Constantius would not commit himself to uncertain fortune but would settle for diplomacy, for soft power.⁶⁰

The campaign of 354 also appears to form a kind of diptych with Julian's operations in 359, which developed and ended very differently. As in the case of Constantius, Julian's desired passage over the Rhine is opposed by the Alamanni (18.2.8–9). Intent on crossing and committed to engaging them in battle, Julian prudently decided to engineer a diversion, and so dispatched three hundred Roman soldiers on forty small boats which crossed the Rhine downstream to outflank the Alamanni (18.2.11–14).⁶¹ Once the territory of Hortarius, a Roman ally, was safely traversed, the adjacent lands not protected by treaty were then pillaged and set ablaze by Julian's troops (2.15). Finally, two Alamannic "kings" and brothers, Macrianus and Hariobaudus, came to sue for peace (2.15–18), which they received (*pax est attributa*, 2.18) after releasing all their Roman prisoners (2.19). This request of Macrianus and Hariobaudus, in contrast to the proposal that Gundomadus and Vadomarius had made to Constantius, was made not because of unfavorable auspices or a diminished ardor for war on the part of the Alamanni but because, we are told, they were afraid that Julian would continue to slaughter them (*sibi perniciem sentientes uenerant pacem anxiiis animis precaturi*, 2.15), an explanation and depiction which further supports Julian as *bellicosus ductor*.⁶² This campaign, with all its points of duality, might also be intended by Ammianus to evoke Constantius' lackluster encounter with the Alamanni in 354.

While Constantius' bridge had remained incomplete and his crossing was thwarted, Julian, conversely, found a way to cross with his army, raze enemy territory, and compel the Alamanni to seek peace on his own terms; Constantius, by contrast, had received terms, deemed them

⁶⁰ Cf. Seager 1999, 581. Note Seager's characterization of what Constantius is saying in his speech at 14.10.11–15: "one should fight only when all else fails" (586).

⁶¹ Cf. Amm. 17.1.4–7, for a similar maneuver right after the battle of Argentoratum. Perhaps the bookish Julian had read about Hannibal's stratagem in Polybius (3.42–43). Note also Julian's earlier use of a "crescent-shaped formation" (*bicornem figuram*, Amm. 16.2.13; cf. μνηοειδές, Polyb. 3.113.8) in 356. The young Caesar carried a library with him on campaign and likely used historical works such as that of Polybius and Julius Caesar, in part, as de facto tactical manuals (cf. Jul. Or. 2, 123D–24D; Ep. 26 (Bidez 1924) 414C).

⁶² Cf. Amm. 29.4.2, where Macrianus is described quite differently when dealing with Valentinian: *ut Macrianum regem auctum inter mutationes crebras sententiarum iamque in nostros adultis uiribus exsurgentem*. And again at 30.3.4: *et uenit immane quo quantoque flatu distentus ut futurus arbiter superior pacis*.

acceptable, and ratified them (14.10.10, 14). The depiction of Julian's successful flanking maneuver has the effect of casting him as a dynamic and imaginative general, whereas Constantius comes off as a static and textbook tactician who plays it safe to a great extent. Constantius was willing to test his fortune only so far in pursuit of achievement; and in his eyes the armistice offered by the Alamanni amounted to sufficient achievement. Furthermore, Constantius' campaign in 354 was in response to recent Alamannic raids (14.10.1). However, Julian predicated his own expedition in 359 on the mere possibility of future Alamannic aggression (*ausuros immania, ni ipsi quoque ad ceterorum sternerentur exempla*, 18.2.1),⁶³ and so, willing to take on greater risk, he applied his imagination and daring to a preemptive strike which unmistakably earns Ammianus' approval. Ammianus is consistent in his presentation of the distinct policies of each emperor on the northern frontiers.

In 355, following his treaty with the brothers Gundomadus and Vadomarius, a new campaign was executed by Constantius against two Alamannic tribes, though only the identity of the second one (the Lentienses) is known due to the lacunose state of the passage (15.4.1).⁶⁴ Yet again, we are told that there was lengthy deliberation (*digestis diu consiliis*), and thus uncertainty, on Constantius' part about committing to battle. And just as in the campaign of 354, Constantius' motivation for war here is to mount a response to Alamannic incursions into Roman territory (15.4.1). Having arrived at the Campi Canini in Raetia, Constantius directed that the *magister equitum* Arbitio take the more powerful part of the army forward to engage both the unknown tribe and the Lentienses, who were apparently allied and deployed their forces together, while the emperor himself remained behind in camp. Ammianus tells us *id uisum est honestum et utile*, evidently meaning that it was Constantius who considered the situation to be so.⁶⁵ At first, the impatient Arbitio pressed on and found his way into a trap, which proved costly to the Romans and forced him and the army to retreat (15.4.7–8; cf. 17.1.8). While Constantius watched from a distance, Arbitio's tribunes, in place of

⁶³ Ammianus emphasizes this preference for preemptive strikes again at 21.5.13, where Julian is preparing to march against Constantius: *his Iulianus, ut poscebat negotii magnitudo, praestructis expertus, quid in rebus tumultuosis anteuersio ualeat et praegressus*.

⁶⁴ See Rollinger 1998.

⁶⁵ Cf. 14.10.14: *ut cunctator et cautus utiliumque monitor*. See also O'Brien 2013a, 230, who notes the undermining effect of what is *utile* and *honestum* in Constantius' speech at 14.10. Consequently, their repeated use here similarly undermines Constantius as a commander.

their now reluctant leader, rallied the Roman army and counterattacked the following day, forcing the tribesmen to break and flee (15.4.10–11). Unlike during the campaign of 354, there was an engagement this time. However, Constantius did not follow up this victory and pursue the two tribes or even seek a peace treaty in light of their defeat, but once again he retired back to Mediolanum, satisfied with their mere dispersal (15.4.13).

This strategy of driving off an enemy and being content to end a campaign with only a pseudo-victory was earlier followed by Constantius in the East against the Persians in the 340s (cf. *Lib. Or.* 59, 76, 81, 88, 96; *Or.* 18, 205–7); it was repeated in the West against the Alamanni in campaigns throughout 354–55, and apparently also in 356 (*Amm.* 16.12.15–16). In fact, this policy was also applied in the subsequent mission of the *magister peditum* Barbatio,⁶⁶ a punitive effort against the Iuthungi who devastated Raetia in 357: simply put, Barbatio was only directed to repel them from Roman territory with a strong force (*ad quos repellendos cum ualida manu missus Barbatio*, 17.6.2).

The underlying purpose of Constantius' operations at this time appears to be cooperation with Julian,⁶⁷ in keeping with the emperor's previously stated intentions to Julian during his investiture back in late 355 that they would be campaigning together (*militabimus simul*, 15.8.14); the aim was a continued effort to sweep the region clear of raiding Germanic tribes. Although Constantius had been prevented from crossing the Rhine in 354, he succeeded in doing so in 356 and pursued, but did not engage, the hidden Alamanni in their own territories until the latter sued for peace (16.12.15; cf. *Jul. Or.* 3, 74B, [Bidez 1932]). Constantius unexpectedly crossed the Rhine into enemy spaces (*spatia*) and lands (*terras*) at the height of winter and seemingly felt no hesitation in this instance as he had the upper hand; he had built his pontoon bridge unopposed and quickly surprised the Alamanni before they could learn of his approach and organize resistance as they had in 354. Yet after merely driving the Alamanni before him, Constantius halted the Roman advance and went no further.

By comparison, Ammianus, while he generally uses *spatia* and *terras* together to describe the area traversed by Constantius, alternatively uses *regna* and *terras* (18.2.14–15) in a similar context to define the distances covered by Julian's march in 359, which serves to highlight the varying degrees of territorial penetration and, consequently, the divergent

⁶⁶ *PLRE* 1.146–47, Barbatio.

⁶⁷ Cf. Austin 1979, 56–58.

objectives of each: Constantius intended to cross the Rhine in order to reassert Roman power, but to march only as far as the immediate area before the German bank of the Rhine, temporarily to clear the vicinity of the enemy, and to depart; whereas Julian was more determined to penetrate deeper into the Alamannic interior to assault the heart of the hostiles' sanctuaries and reimpose Roman power before disengaging.

Now a pattern and thus a formula for what Constantius deemed to be sufficient achievement on the northern frontiers begins to form. Despite having the upper hand in 356, Constantius still closed the campaign in a manner reminiscent of 354: "Afterwards, however, with peace having been granted, the emperor departed" (*postea uero pace data discesserat imperator*, 16.12.16).⁶⁸ Yet, unlike his earlier view that it was right to agree to peace since it was asked for on just conditions (*pacem oportere tribui, quae iustis condicionibus petebatur*, 14.10.10; [*pacem*] *tribui debere censeo multa contemplanis*, 14.10.14), Constantius here is explicitly said to have "granted" (*data*) it, and therefore to have offered terms in Raetia in 356 and closed what seems to have been a short but more successful campaign. This success is downplayed, although it would appear to fit well with Ammianus' support for hard power and the conventional approach to waging war and then closing it: attack first and then offer peace from a superior military position.

Nevertheless, these expeditions across the Rhine, and subsequently the Danube, which could have penetrated deeper into barbarian domains, were not vigorously carried out and were ultimately rejected in favor of limited responses that were restricted to the established Roman defensive perimeter of the Rhine-Danube *limes*. As Constantius had previously engaged the Alamanni near Augusta Rauracorum on the Upper Rhine, the theater of operations remained in Raetia from 355–57.⁶⁹ The emperor did not campaign on the Lower Rhine, perhaps because Raetia, and specifically the area of Augusta Rauracorum, formed the linchpin between the Rhine and Danube *limes*; and Raetia was therefore an advantageous middle point which allowed Constantius the flexibility to respond quickly to any potential disturbance in Gaul or Illyricum, as the eastern frontier was relatively quiet at this time. Reassertion of Roman authority via expulsion, not reconquest, was Constantius' order of the day. In fact, Constantius' presence on the Raetian front may have been intended

⁶⁸For Ammianus' occasional use of the pluperfect in place of the perfect, see de Jonge 1972a, 37 (*mandauerat*, 14.7.12); den Boeft et al. 1987, 33 (*aduerterant*, 20.3.3), 61 (*acquieuerat*, 20.4.4), 262; Barnes 1998, 49, n. 19 (*dederat*, 23.1.2).

⁶⁹See Amm. 15.4.1, 16.11.2, 16.12.15–16, 17.6.1.

only to “close the door” and block the Alamanni from penetrating Gaul through the Upper Rhine.⁷⁰ The apparent motive behind this policy was to maintain territorial integrity and frontier security through low-risk, controlled sweeping movements. Ammianus portrays Constantius’ actions on the Rhine between 354–56 in such a way that we can clearly see an emperor who is restrained, and perhaps somewhat timid, in the face of Germanic belligerence.

As has already been noted above, Constantius is often criticized by Ammianus for his lack of success against a foreign enemy when compared with his success in civil conflicts. Ammianus’ use of the joint terms “reluctant and cautious” (*ut cunctator et cautus*, 14.10.14) to Constantius’ detriment against the Alamanni is reinforced by the historian’s ironic and negative description of Valentinian “like a reluctant and wary general” (*ut dux cunctator et tutus*, 27.10.10), also against the Alamanni.⁷¹ Furthermore, it cannot be a coincidence that Ammianus applies *cunctator et cautus*, first introduced at the end of Book 14, only once more in the *Res Gestae*, at the end of Book 31 to describe the *magister equitum* Victor (*sed cunctator et cautus*, 31.12.6).⁷² In fact, this nearly identical language, which must represent an intentional cross-reference, serves as an intratextual connection between Books 14 and 31 and further supports the view of Ammianus’ *History* as a unity.

In my view, however, the intended meaning in each case is different.⁷³ In the context of a diminished ardor for war (*mollito rigore*) on the part of the Alamanni in 354, *ut cunctator et cautus* seems meant to disparage Constantius for suspending operations and deciding to accept the peace terms they proposed; while for Victor the same epithet, deployed in light of Valens’ ill-fated decision at Adrianople against the

⁷⁰ Austin 1979, 54–55. Cf. Rosen 1968, 79–80.

⁷¹ See Seager 1996, 192–95. Ammianus also styles Valentinian *princeps . . . cautissimus* (27.9.2) and in the necrology states *Ad inferenda propulsanda bella sollertissime cautus, aestu Martii pulueris induratus* (30.9.4). These uses of *cautus*, especially the latter one, serve to cement Valentinian’s poor military reputation.

⁷² *PLRE* 1.957–59, Victor 4. Cf. Sabbah 1978, 420–21, n. 59, for the description of Victor, among others, as replete with remarks which qualify his character.

⁷³ Cf. den Boeft et al. 2011, 90, for the assertion that “The combination *cunctator et cautus* denotes the prudent military strategy of an emperor in 14.10.14 and 31.12.6.” This is a strange statement, for the depiction at 31.12.6 is not made of an emperor, but of Victor, and in any case it is advice that is not followed by Valens. The circumstances of the two usages vary widely; it would be better to say that the combination in 14.10.14 denotes Constantius’ timidity, while that in 31.12.6 denotes Victor’s prudent military strategy, one that Valens should have followed.

energized and confident Goths (*tumor barbaricus flammans*, 31.12.6) in 378 to ignore Victor's counsel and not wait for Gratian (31.12.7), is a compliment. How can Ammianus use *cunctator et cautus* in these two cases under such diverse circumstances and not intend each usage to mean something different? Indeed, when we remember that Theodosius the Elder is rendered *ut antiquus ille Cunctator* (29.5.32), we see that he is so styled in the context of an enemy who not only outnumbers the Romans (29.5.29) but is also cast as "pugnacious and successful in the hurling of spears" (*pugnacem et impetrabilem iactu telorum*, 29.5.32). The language and context here both contribute to make Theodosius a kind of Fabius Maximus. Thus, Ammianus here, for the most part, appears to be praising Theodosius; the distinctive *ut* is in the first position, but it is necessary since *antiquus* clearly evokes Fabius and so is a direct historical comparative.⁷⁴ But Ammianus does not appear to convey *cunctator* in the same sense in the examples of Constantius, Victor, and Theodosius; that of Constantius stands out. This interpretation is supported further when we consider one slight, but key difference between the description of Constantius at 14.10.14 and that of Victor at 31.12.6: the latter does not contain an *ut*, signifying that Victor actually *is* "reluctant and cautious" in a proper sense, whereas Constantius had only been playing the part. This is consistent with Ammianus' descriptions elsewhere, such as when he styles Julian *moderatus et tranquillus* and *consideratus et cautus* at 21.5.5, yet supplies an *ut* for Constantius' descriptions, such as *ut cunctator et cautus* and *ut princeps tranquillus*. In the latter cases, the connective *ut* does not introduce purpose, result, or an indirect command, but a simile or comparative of Constantius which negatively depicts his character (cf. n. 42).

Furthermore, we should recall that Julian is styled "a warlike leader" (*bellicosi ductoris*, 16.12.18), a description which is also not qualified with an *ut*.⁷⁵ And it is significant that Ammianus similarly labels other Roman generals and emperors as *bellicosus* (also without an *ut*), an adjective that constitutes his highest military praise: the *magistri* Ursicinus, Severus,

⁷⁴ Cf. Blockley 1975, 193, and den Boeft et al. 2013, 192–93, who see this as a positive evocation. But Seager 1997, 6, has observed that it is followed by language which might mitigate an aspect of its positive value, namely, prudence: *si fors copiam dederit*. See also Amm. 29.5.39: *ut pugnator ille cautus et prudens*. This is an overloading of praise that spews insincerity (cf. den Boeft et al. 2013, 199; n. 77 below). On Ammianus' careful rendering of Theodosius the Elder, see Thompson 1969, 87–107; Seager 1997; Mratschek 2007.

⁷⁵ See also Amm. 21.12.22: *bellicoso . . . rectori*. 25.6.10: *imperatorem bellicosum et uigilantem*.

and Lupicinus are all described as “warlike,” as are the emperors Trajan, Septimius Severus, and Gratian.⁷⁶ Yet neither Constantius nor Valentinian receives the title of *bellicosus ductor*;⁷⁷ and Valentinian is also uniquely styled “as was befitting a reluctant general” (*ut cunctatorem decuerat ducem*, 30.3.2) when considering a response to a bold barbarian infiltration of the Danube frontier (*ausos temerare limitem barbaros*) in 374. But the emperor does not respond, instead choosing to negotiate with the Alamannic “king” Macrianus. Here it is Macrianus alone, and not the Alamanni as a whole, who then came furiously and stood raising his head higher (*et uenit immane . . . caput altius erigens stetit*, 30.3.4), and, therefore, he comes off better when compared with Valentinian, who chose to avoid confrontation. This depiction of Macrianus is reminiscent of the Alamanni who opposed Julian, *bellicosus ductor*, at Argentoratum (*erexit autem confidentiam caput altius attollentium*, 16.12.2). It is through such subtle language and allusion that the quality of generalship and the frontier policies of Constantius and Valentinian are generally derided through an implicit comparison with Julian. However, in one episode, Julian, too, is called *cunctator*, which needs to be explored.

In 356, an increasingly experienced Julian, fresh from an ambush near Decem Pagi prior to the recapture of Colonia Agrippina (Cologne), *erat prouidus et cunctator, quod praecipuum bonum in magnis ductoribus* (16.2.11). First, just as with *bellicosus ductor*, there is no qualifying *ut* here; and Ammianus makes his intended meaning crystal clear via the relative clause, which Constantius does not have at 14.10.14 (nor Valentinian at 27.10.10). Second, unlike Valentinian, Julian avoided being personally caught up in an ambush and humiliated and was able with reinforcements to drive off those attacking his rear. The first epithet explains the second; thus, Ammianus is complimenting Julian, who is subsequently reluctant because he is farsighted, whereas Constantius, like Valentinian, incurs

⁷⁶ Amm. 14.9.1: *Ursicinus . . . bellicosus sane milesque semper et militum ductor*. 19.3.3: *bellicosus homo*. 17.10.1: *Seuerus magister equitum bellicosus ante haec et industrius*. 20.1.2: *Lupicinus . . . magistrum armorum, bellicosum sane et castrensis rei peritum*. 25.8.5: *Traianus et Seuerus principes bellicosi*. 31.10.18: *Gratianus . . . facundus et moderatus et bellicosus et clemens*.

⁷⁷ Also, neither Constantius nor Valentinian is afforded *efficacia*. And while Constantius receives *ductor* once at 17.13.26, it is an unadorned title that Constantius applies to himself in his *adlocutio*. As for Valentinian, *ductor* is also bestowed upon him once unadorned (30.5.2), interestingly enough, while he is on the Danube. But Ammianus treats Theodosius the Elder better, if not insincerely (cf. n. 74): *ductor exercituum ille magnificus* (28.6.26) and *amplissimus ductor* (29.5.45). The *magister equitum per Gallias* Jovinus (*ductor egregius*, 27.2.8) and Claudius Gothicus (*glorioso ductore*, 31.5.17) come off better.

what we can term the double-negative construction of “reluctant and cautious/wary” without the same justification or any prophetic power. That Ammianus similarly applies *cunctator* to Julian and Victor, and also to Constantius and Valentinian, reveals that he skillfully uses this epithet either to praise or censure, depending on the subject and circumstances.

Indeed, at 28.1.44, Ammianus tells us that another Ursicinus (not Ammianus’ former commander and patron, but the *uicarius urbis Romae*) *ut cunctator contemptus*, or “was detested as a reluctant man,” for only mildly investigating charges of *maiestas*.⁷⁸ This tells us a few things. First, that Ammianus was well aware of a negative connotation of *cunctator*, at least as it is used here; second, that it is not Ammianus’ own estimation of Ursicinus, as his use of *contemptus* reveals; it was likely the opinion of Ursicinus’ detractors at Valentinian’s court. One wonders if Ammianus here wants his readers to be reminded of the *magister equitum* Ursicinus, his former commander and patron, and his troubles with Constantius’ court which, like the other Ursicinus above, ended with his dismissal (cf. Amm. 20.2).⁷⁹ Moreover, the *ut* at 28.1.44 serves to qualify the remark. By preceding the description of an important figure with such an *ut*, the historian thus distances himself from the comment and shows that he does not completely agree with it. In fact, the description at 28.1.44 further supports viewing *ut dux cunctator et tutus* (Valentinian), already established as ironic and negative, in a similar light to *ut cunctator et cautus* (Constantius).

Additionally, in keeping with his earlier description of “prudent and reluctant” (*prouidus et cunctator*, 16.2.11) in wartime, Ammianus also styles Julian as “deliberate and cautious” (*consideratus et cautus*, 21.5.5) when about to engage Constantius in civil war, once again without an *ut*, which is significant and must signify due caution. If we recall Ammianus’ numerous references to Constantius’ record in foreign wars as poor when compared with his success in civil conflicts (14.10.16, 14.11.8, 21.16.5), Julian’s record on the Rhine is favorably highlighted here at 21.5, as he is called “a fortunate conqueror over foreign nations and kings” (*fortunatum domitorem gentium appellans et regum*, 21.5.9),⁸⁰ which would remind readers that Constantius had not been nearly as successful. A more risk-oriented Julian actually surpassed his mandate by re-extending Roman boundaries in Gaul and Germany back to their former limits under the

⁷⁸ *PLRE* 1.987, Ursicinus 6. Cf. den Boeft et al. 2011, 89–90.

⁷⁹ *PLRE* 1.985–86, Ursicinus 2.

⁸⁰ Cf. Szidat 1996, 44.

High Empire of the Antonines.⁸¹ Indeed, in Ammianus, reannexation and restoration of Antonine boundaries and borderlands between Rome and Greater Germany is the focus of Julian's program of hard power on the Rhine, in contrast to Constantius, who prefers just to hold on to the territory he has inherited and to maintain the status quo, in the East and West, and makes the limited expulsion and pacification of invaders the fulcrum of what he considers successful frontier policy.

II

When compared with his earlier campaigns on the Rhine, Constantius' time on the Danube constitutes a continuity of policy. To be sure, Constantius was to remain active through 358–59 against the Sarmatians, Quadi, and Limigantes along the Danube frontier, where he would replicate his Rhine policy against all who threatened Roman territory by either compelling them to flee or to sue for peace.⁸² In the spring of 358, the emperor departed from Sirmium (Sremska Mitrovica) and once again undertook a campaign in reaction to enemy raids (16.10.20, 17.12.1). He was able to build a pontoon bridge, rapidly cross into enemy territory, and make the Roman presence felt (17.12.4), successfully cutting down Sarmatians who were fleeing before the Roman advance and razing the area of Sarmatia closest to Valeria (12.5–6). Soon afterwards, the Quadi joined the conflict on the side of the Sarmatians (12.8). Constantius continued his advance and reached the domain of the Quadi, who then confidently came to the emperor in order to supplicate for peace (*rogaturi suppliciter pacem fidentes ad principis uenere conspectum*, 12.9).

Interestingly, there is a clear indication of Ammianus' disapproval here when he tells us, immediately after the Quadi sue for peace, that Constantius was "too lenient towards these and similar [crimes]" (*principis . . . erga haec et similia lenioris*, 12.9).⁸³ We have seen Ammianus comment

⁸¹ Claud. Mamert. 3.1; Lib. Or. 18, 90; Eutrop. 10.14.2: *multa postea per eundem Iulianum egregia aduersum barbaros gesta sunt summotique ultra Rhenum Germani et finibus suis Romanum imperium restitutum*.

⁸² Amm. 17.12.4–21, 17.13.5–34, 19.11.1–17; Seager 1999, 582–87. See also Szidat 1972 and Barceló 1992.

⁸³ Cf. Amm. 14.1.8: *erga haec et similia multa scrutandi* (Gallus Caesar). 14.7.12: *Montius tunc quaestor, acer quidem, sed ad lenitatem propensior*. 19.12.6: *datumque est negotium Modesto etiamtum per orientem comiti, apto ad haec et similia* [*similia* in Clark]. *Hermogenes enim Ponticus ea tempestate praefectus praetorio ut lenior ingenii spernebatur*. 21.6.2: *Constantius circa haec lenior solito*.

on Constantius' *lenitas* before, in an *adlocutio* in 354 (*postremo . . . qui sentit expertus nec fortitudinem in rebelles nec lenitatem in supplices animos abesse*, 14.10.14),⁸⁴ just after the emperor declares that he is *ut cunctator et cautus*. It would appear that, in the context of the Quadi asking for peace, Ammianus disapproves of Constantius' engaging in diplomacy at 17.12.9, a view that may also be present in the historian's telling of accepted peace overtures from the Alamanni at 14.10.14. This use of the adjective *lenior* at 17.12.9 notwithstanding, the overall vocabulary and textual placement of Constantius' campaigns here by Ammianus represents the latter's approval and praise (cf. Barnes 1998, 138), albeit to a limited extent; for the treatment of Constantius again sets up for readers a juxtaposition with the actions of Julian, who comes off better.⁸⁵

Nevertheless, the historian seems to approve of how negotiations with the Sarmatians were conducted by Constantius once they were underway, as they were done with fairness and benevolence (*praeualuit tamen aequitati iuncta benignitas*, 17.12.11); and the Transiugitani and Quadi likewise were treated fairly and rightly (*his ex aequo bonoque compositis*, 17.12.14).⁸⁶ Two key byproducts of the negotiations were the release of Roman prisoners held from recent raids (17.12.11, 16, 20) and the turning over of hostages, a development recorded for the first time by Ammianus (17.12.11, 13, 15–16, 21). In fact, Constantius' request for hostages appears connected by Ammianus to a fear of these peoples by the emperor (*quorum plebem ueritus imperator*, 17.12.12), which the

⁸⁴ Cf. Seager 1999, 582, n. 16, presuming this allusion but not convinced that *lenior* is used pejoratively. However, it is fairly clear that Ammianus does in fact use it pejoratively when we look at how he uses it elsewhere (cf. n. 83 above). Moreover, it is significant that Julian is never styled *lenior* in a military context; the closest he apparently gets is reflected in a hope by the Antiochenes, after the appointment of the turbulent and cruel Alexander of Heliopolis as governor of Syria (23.2.3), that Julian *placabilis esset et lenior* (23.2.4) when he returns from Persia. In any case, the context in which *lenior* is used here is a civil one. Ammianus similarly uses *lenior* later in order to emphasize Maximinus' harsh wielding of civil authority (*nihilo lenior fuit, etiam longius nocens ut basilisci serpentes*, 28.1.41), which is reminiscent of Gallus Caesar's behavior at Antioch (*post quorum necem nihilo lenius ferociens Gallus*, 14.9.9).

⁸⁵ Cf. Austin 1979, 55, for either Ammianus' possible ignorance on Constantius' campaign plans in Raetia in 356 or his suppression of information in order to talk up Julian. See also Gärtner 1968, 502, n. 2; and Seager 1983, 155–56, for Constantius as a foil to Julian in Claudius Mamertinus' *Gratiarum Actio*.

⁸⁶ It is noteworthy that Ammianus never uses such language to describe Julian's diplomatic efforts. In fact, Ammianus tends to pass over them, jumping ahead to the end result, namely, a peace treaty. Thus we should not exclude the possibility that Ammianus describes Constantius' diplomatic undertakings here in such a way so as to show him, once again, as being less warlike than Julian.

historian may be alluding to in the next chapter (17.13),⁸⁷ meaning that Constantius did not trust them. To highlight this campaign as an exception to Constantius' previously stated misfortune against foreign foes, Ammianus singularly opens the campaign by relating that Constantius "proceeded under the direction of a more joyful fortune" (*imperator . . . ductu laetioris fortunae profectus*, 17.12.4) and later closes it with "fate is to be conquered or made by the power of an emperor" (*fatum uinci principis potestate uel fieri*, 17.12.17).⁸⁸

Overall, with his crossing of the Danube and campaign against the Sarmatians and Quadi in 358 (12.4–21), Constantius, in this one instance, mirrors most closely the martial formula of Julian: namely, the crossing of a river via a pontoon bridge into enemy territory and ravaging it (12.4–6); the defeat of enemy forces (12.5, 9) and the subsequent penetration of their kingdom (*ad Quadorum regna properabat exercitus*, 12.9; *uiso exercitu in gremio regni*, 12.21); the procession of suppliant chiefs begging for peace (12.9–16); the ratification of peace (12.11, 14–16, 21); and the release of Roman prisoners (12.11, 16, 20). Yet the historian seems to show Constantius adding a new ingredient to the formula: hostages (12.11, 13, 15–16, 21). In Ammianus, it is only after military victory that Julian turns to diplomacy (cf. 18.2.15–19):⁸⁹ first to demand the release of all Roman prisoners and then the ratification of a treaty and the mutual observance of a new status quo. However, one component is omitted: Julian's keeping of Germanic hostages to help the tribesmen keep faith with the pact made. Although Ammianus has suppressed it, Julian also demanded enemy hostages, perhaps consistently throughout his tenure in Gaul, as an assurance of peace.⁹⁰ In fact, according to Eunapius, Julian took the son of the Alamannic "king" Vadomarius, perhaps Vithicabius (we do not know how many sons Vadomarius had), as a hostage for a brief time.⁹¹ One likely reason for Ammianus' suppression of Julian's use

⁸⁷ Cf. Amm. 17.13.25: *tali textu recte factorum Constantius iam metuente sublimior*. On this statement, see Szidat 1972, 713: "Diese Aussage ist eindeutig negativ für Constantius zu bewerten, denn die Furcht wird mehrmals als ein Charakterzug erwähnt, der besonders kennzeichnend für ihn ist."

⁸⁸ Cf. Sabbah 1978, 325–26, n. 20, for Ammianus' use of an official panegyric for this phrase at 17.12.17. See also Szidat 1972, 712–13, 716–17; Barceló 1992, 424–25.

⁸⁹ See also Amm. 16.3, 17.1, 17.8, 17.10, 21.4.7–8; Jul. *Ep. ad Athen.* 280B–C.

⁹⁰ Jul. *Ep. ad Athen.* 280B–C; Lib. *Or.* 12, 50; Eunap. *Frag.* 18.6.10–20, 54–58, 66–68, 19 (Blockley 1983); Zos. 3.7.7.

⁹¹ Eunap. *Frag.* 19. See Woods 2000, 696, who sees Ammianus' omission here as an attempt to protect Julian's reputation from Vadomarius and Vithicabius' subsequent actions on the Rhine. Cf. Amm. 21.3, 27.10.3–4, 30.7.7.

of hostages is that he wants to project the view that Julian's effectiveness and reputation as a general alone were sufficient to ensure that the barbarians kept the peace,⁹² whereas Constantius lacked this advantage and so needed hostages to ensure that his treaties were faithfully observed. If correct, such an omission serves as an example of Ammianus slighting Constantius, whom the historian explicitly states had requested hostages.

Moreover, while Ammianus brands Constantius *lenior* (17.12.9), he conversely suppresses the extent to which Julian was ruthless. At some point during Julian's first campaigns in 356–57, some Roman soldiers, eager for rewards, brought back the heads of fallen Germans—one head, one *solidus*.⁹³ With creative ruthlessness, Julian had kept his previously restless soldiers both pacified and motivated through this gold-for-heads program. Not surprisingly, Ammianus also omits describing Julian's active use of Charietto and his band as guerrillas against the Chamavi, probably for the same reason that such tactics were seen as dishonorable, and that they would therefore distract and undermine the narrative of Julian's noble approach to warfare and heroic exploits (cf. Blockley 1977, 230);⁹⁴ all that Ammianus saw worthy of recording was Charietto's remarkable bravery and allotted task alongside the tribune Nestica to capture an Alamannic guide (17.10.5), his subsequent appointment by Julian as *comes per utramque Germaniam* (27.1.2),⁹⁵ and his heroic end against some Alamanni in 365 (27.1.5).⁹⁶ If Julian first implemented his brutal

⁹² Cf. Amm. 22.9.1, 25.4.14, 30.7.5, where Julian's military success and reputation, his connection to Fortuna, are emphasized as reasons for the Alamanni and others keeping the peace as long as he lived.

⁹³ Lib. *Or.* 18, 45, 73; Soc. 3.1.27–28; Soz. 5.2.21.

⁹⁴ Lib. *Or.* 18, 104; Eunap. *Frag.* 18.3–5; Zos. 3.7.2–6, for Charietto's counterinsurgency; *PLRE* 1.200, Charietto 1; Paschoud 1979, 78–80. Much has been made of Photius' description of Zosimus as "the epitomator of Eunapius" (*Bibl.* 98); therefore, it is odd that Zosimus confuses the Chamavi with the Quadi here (Zos. 3.7.6–7; cf. Eunap. *Frag.* 18.6.15–45). Indeed, Zosimus knew that the Quadi resided along the Danube and that they were dealt with by Constantius (Zos. 3.1.1, 3.2.2; Amm. 17.12; Ridley 2004, 171, n. 27). Note also that Ammianus quietly introduces Charietto as one of Julian's trusted agents against the Alamanni (17.10.5) after first relating events regarding the Chamavi (17.8.5). For recent studies of Charietto, see Paschoud 2002 and Welwei and Meier 2003. See also Amm. 28.5.7, for Ammianus' awareness of the possible reception of guerilla warfare.

⁹⁵ On Charietto's holding of this rank, see Scharf 2005, 28–34. In my view, Julian likely promoted Charietto to *comes per utramque Germaniam* ca. 360/1 due to the latter's remarkable success as an effective leader of guerilla fighters along the Rhine and due to his faithful service; but Ammianus likely omits telling us about this promotion because it would entail revealing Julian's hand in Charietto's less than heroic activities.

⁹⁶ Cf. den Boeft et al. 2009, 3–10.

policy in 356/7, we can see why he so well appreciated Charietto's own ruthlessness (cf. Zos. 3.7.2–3) and employed him and his band in 358–59 as a successful counterinsurgency force.

As for Constantius, his military policy was reactive and less ruthless, constantly geared towards limited warfare without follow-up. This is further illustrated by a protracted campaign conducted from Sirmium (Amm. 17.12.1) that continued against the Limigantes in 358–59, again in response to their raids (17.13.1, 27), when Constantius remained on the Danube for some time while his soldiers crossed to the enemy bank in boats and cut many of them down (17.13.15–20).⁹⁷ However, there was no pontoon bridge constructed this time, and the small strike force of light-armed troops (*uelites expediti*, 13.17) went no further than the vicinity of the enemy bank before returning to the Roman side. Ammianus explains the limited aim of this campaign by earlier relaying that the emperor had decided that Roman honor was “to be avenged leniently” (*lenius uindicari*, 13.2), a term which may very well reflect an imperial “spin” of the emperor's relative lack of aggression.⁹⁸ Indeed, Ammianus has already noted Constantius' *lenitas* at 14.10.14 and 17.12.9. It is indicative of Constantius' general partiality for restrained warfare that the initial plan was not to attack the Limigantes but first to employ soft power, diplomacy, to bid the Limigantes to accept relocation (17.13.2). In fact, unlike the previous campaign where Constantius appeared determined to invade Sarmatia and eventually did so (17.12.4), and subsequently entered into negotiations (17.12.11), the emperor was prepared to engage in diplomacy with the Limigantes right from the start (17.13.5). But Constantius suspected treachery and the Romans attacked later in the day and killed many of them (17.13.5–19).⁹⁹ Not long afterwards, the Limigantes were successfully relocated, and others, deemed more respectable and safe, were welcomed into the region (17.13.24, 30). Having slaughtered and followed through against the Limigantes, Constantius then acted leniently and at the right time (*hisque secundo finitis euentu lenitatis tempus aderat tempestiuae*, 17.13.30); that is, to have done so before a more complete victory was achieved—perhaps a reference to the previous movement against the

⁹⁷ See Philostorg, *HE* 4.3a, *Art. Pass.* 16: ἀπάρας ἀπὸ τοῦ Σιρμίου, πρὸς τὸν Ἰστρον διέβη. καὶ πρὸς αὐτῇ τῇ ὁχθῇ χρόνον οὐκ ὀλίγον ποιήσας.

⁹⁸ Sabbah 1978, 209; Seager 1996, 191. Possibly lifted from an official communiqué to the Limigantes in 359. If correct, this reinforces the earlier description of Constantius *ut cunctator et cautus utiliumque monitor* at 14.10.14.

⁹⁹ Cf. Seager 1999, 583–84, who observes that Constantius may have intended to attack all along.

Sarmatians and Quadi (17.12.9)—would have been the wrong time. It is instructive that Ammianus has Constantius himself tell us about this timely leniency at 17.13.30 in an *adlocutio* (below), a leniency he subsequently emphasizes with *pepercimus*. This statement serves as a substantiation of imperial policy as outlined at 17.13.2 (*lenius uindicari*) and gives other statements regarding Constantius' leniency greater authenticity, just as with his self-description *ut cunctator et cautus* at 14.10.14. The historian has clear-cut ideas about leniency: he seems to favor it in proper negotiations (17.12.11) and in civil matters (23.2.4, 28.1.41; cf. n. 84), but not during combat. Once battle has commenced, only overwhelming force will do.¹⁰⁰

Interestingly, Constantius' valor in battle goes unmentioned by ecclesiastical historians who recorded Julian's success in Gaul, particularly his remarkable victory at Argentoratum. Apparently, not even Philostorgius (albeit fragmentary), who is sympathetic to Constantius, had anything substantial to say about Constantius' campaigns on the northern frontiers (cf. n. 97 above). Instead, it is the pagan Ammianus who relates Constantius' defeat of the Sarmatians and Limigantes, and who remarkably caps it with approbation in a most lengthy *adlocutio* (17.13.26–33) by the emperor: “Truly, it is fitting for valor to be content with what it has acquired by hard work and a strong right arm” (*his enim uirtutem oportet esse contentam, quae sudore quaesiuit et dexteris*, 17.13.31). This unique approbation is preceded by two noteworthy markers. First, this speech, unlike Constantius' early one at 14.10.11–15 but like Julian's at 16.12.9–12, seems to be registered here favorably: *Constantius . . . adlocutus est* (17.13.25; cf. n. 26); second, he is referred to as *ductor* (17.13.26), though the value of the appellation is diminished by two factors: it is Constantius' self-attribution, whereas Julian had received his appellation from a standard-bearer, and, unlike Julian's, it is unadorned. Approval of Constantius also appears to be discernible in the historian's use of *alacrior solito* to close the description of the campaign (17.13.34), a noteworthy point because Ammianus first uses this phrase approvingly to describe the initial movements of Julian in Gaul in 356 (*solito alacrior*, 16.2.9).¹⁰¹ Yet approval of Constantius is again qualified, as the enthusiasm of his troops is due not to their positive opinion of his generalship per se, but to

¹⁰⁰ E.g., see 16.11.8–10, 16.12.50–56, 17.10.6–7, 17.12.4–9, 17.13.10–24, 18.2.15.

¹⁰¹ See also Kelly 2008, 301–3, who compares Ammianus' language at 16.12.55–57 and 17.13.15 and argues that Julian and his victory at Argentoratum are first related by the historian in Book 16 so as to serve as an *exemplum*, one imitated in Book 17 by Constantius whose success then accordingly comes off as “an echo, albeit a diminished one, of Julian's achievements” (303).

their enthusiasm for rewards (*aucta spe potiorum et lucri*, 17.13.34).¹⁰² As with the dual meanings of *cunctator et cautus*, Ammianus' application of *solito alacrior* shows that when it comes to deciphering his descriptions, context and contrast provide new insights. Soon afterwards, Constantius, satisfied with his dispositions on the Danube, retired to Sirmium (17.13.34).

The short campaign of early 359, which Ammianus prefaces with *Inter haec ita ambigua [Constantium]* (19.11.1; cf. n. 43),¹⁰³ began and ended in much the same way as the protracted one of the previous year. Constantius received alarming reports at Sirmium of new incursions by the Limigantes, which propelled him to respond (19.11.1, 5). He then sends two tribunes to investigate and engages in negotiations (11.5–7). There is treachery on the part of the Limigantes, which is revealed when they suddenly attack the emperor's person (11.8–12). Roman soldiers respond, protect the emperor, and engage in retaliatory carnage (11.13–15). Finally, satisfied with the outcome, Constantius returns to Sirmium (11.17). Ammianus is alone among the ancient historians in relating these operations, but he does so in a tone that is less than martial and adulatory with respect to Constantius. In addition to the formulaic expression at 11.1, which taints the entire passage with uncertainty, and the subsequent preemptive negotiations at 11.5–7, we see Constantius hastily riding off at full speed after being attacked (11.11) and leaving the actual fighting to others (11.12),¹⁰⁴ such as the tribune Cella who had been among the first to attack the Limigantes and fell in the thick of battle (11.16).

Nonetheless, the most complete record of Constantius' campaigns is preserved by Ammianus, while the Greek historians Eunapius (albeit fragmentary) and Zosimus through neglect paint an image of inertia as they omit all telling of Constantius' wars on the northern frontiers in order to emphasize Julian's restless military prowess.¹⁰⁵ As a function of military achievement, Constantius' soft power, or his more restrained form of hard power, provided him with little noteworthy praise. Indeed, when the occasions of two panegyrics called for examples of Constantius'

¹⁰² Cf. Szidat 1972, 713; Sabbah 1978, 188, n. 60; Seager 1986, 10–11. See also O'Brien 2013a, 240, 243–44.

¹⁰³ See Barceló 1992.

¹⁰⁴ *externis mixtus et suis ignotusque, dux esset an miles, quia neque cunctandi aderat tempus neque cessandi, equo ueloci impositus cursu effuso euasit* (11.11). See Sabbah 1978, 190, who observes at 19.11.10–12 that “toute ironie n'est pas absente de la représentation appuyée de ce prince, qui voulut toujours s'élever au dessus des autres hommes, fuyant sans gloire dans la cohue des combattants”; Seager 1996, 194–95.

¹⁰⁵ See Zos. 3.2.2, who makes a bald reference to Constantius' Danubian campaigns in 358 before moving on to outline those of Julian on the Rhine in detail.

military prowess,¹⁰⁶ the best that Julian apparently could point to, writing *ca.* late 355/early 356 and 358/9,¹⁰⁷ was a single occasion when Constantius had crossed the Rhine (*Or.* 3, 74B; cf. *Amm.* 16.12.15); several crossings of the Tigris (*Or.* 1, 22A–C; cf. *Lib. Or.* 59, 100); the draw at Singara in 344 (*Or.* 1, 23B, 26A);¹⁰⁸ and a successful defense of Nisibis [on his behalf] in 350 (*Or.* 1, 28D; *Or.* 3, 66C–D; cf. *Fest.* 27.2). That Julian even includes the defense of Nisibis, a siege in which Constantius was likely absent, projects the view that Constantius' military résumé was thin and lack-luster at best.¹⁰⁹ Writing in 361, Julian refers to Constantius' campaigns against the Sarmatians and Quadi on the Danube just three years before, mockingly calling them a “friendly encounter” (φιλιῶς ἐντυχόντος, *Ep. ad Athen.* 279D).¹¹⁰ Reasons of propaganda aside, Julian was undoubtedly measuring Constantius' military practices against his own and judged those of his cousin to be soft by comparison and, therefore, inferior. Perhaps Ammianus himself picked up on this comparison and thus saw fit to use it subtly (e.g., *lenior*), not only to convey his preference for Julian but also to outline key differences in imperial policy between these two figures in the *Res Gestae*.¹¹¹

¹⁰⁶For recent studies of Julian's panegyrics to Constantius, see Curta 1995, Tougher 2012, Drake 2012.

¹⁰⁷See Bidez 1932, 3, for the dating of the first panegyric, and 108–9, for the second, dated to 358. However, it is advisable to also consider 359, before Julian's pronouncement at Paris. Cf. Curta 1995, 194–96, for a possible reference by Julian to a solar eclipse in 359 (*Or.* 3, 80C–D).

¹⁰⁸Cf. *Lib. Or.* 59, 104–20; Eutrop. 10.10.1: *nullumque ei contra Saporem prosperum proelium fuit, nisi quod apud Singaram haud dubiam uictoriam ferocia militum amisit, qui pugnam seditiose et stolide contra rationem belli die iam praecipiti poposcerunt*.

¹⁰⁹Cf. Tougher 2012, 27–28, who notes instances in the first panegyric where Julian has tempered his praise of Constantius' reign, such as references to the Massacre of 337 and the battle of Singara (though Tougher has overlooked that it was a draw). But Julian does not invent; he uses facts and turns them to his advantage, such as those presented in his *Epistle to the Athenians*. However, as scholars have noted, much depends on whether the two panegyrics to Constantius were delivered to him or not, when they were composed and for what purpose.

¹¹⁰Note also that Julian subsequently goes on to use *θεραπεύειν* to describe how the barbarians were treated by Constantius (280B).

¹¹¹See *Amm.* 16.5.7: *ut ostendit orationum epistularumque eius cum grauitate comitas incorrupta*.

III

In keeping with Sharrock's definition of "intratextuality," there has been much chopping and reassembling of Ammianus' text here; but, in the end, it is my belief that what has been reassembled, as a unity, provides a clear sense of the big picture on the northern frontiers under Constantius II and Julian. When his campaigns of 354–57 are compared with those of 358–59 in Ammianus, Constantius seems to be more or less consistent in his preferred approach on the Rhine and Danube. A penchant for defensive warfare is underscored by various descriptions in Constantius' *adlocutio* (14.10.11–15) to the Gallic army in 354 while the Alamanni were gathered on the opposite bank of the Rhine. When we consider Ammianus' penchant for comparison and contrast, both direct and subtle, it appears that the rendering of Constantius *ut cunctator et cautus* at the end of Book 14, made in the context of the *mollito rigore* of the Alamanni, effectively presages the coming of Julian, *bellicosus dux*, who fights an energized Alamanni at the end of Book 16. Both Constantius and Julian face off against the Alamanni and both deliver *adlocutiones* to the Roman army; but only one successfully crosses the Rhine via a pontoon bridge and ends his campaign in victory. Moreover, it seems that Ammianus prefaces descriptions with which he does not agree, at least partially, with an *ut*, such as in *ut cunctator et cautus*, which, I argue, is actually meant to be an ironic and negative evaluation of Constantius' generalship. As for Julian, Ammianus' hero, it is significant that we do not find his descriptions qualified with such an *ut*. When we consider Ammianus' partiality for Julian over Constantius and Valentinian, and the context of their descriptions and their intratextuality in the *Res Gestae*, I believe that we have other examples of Ammianus' masterful and subversive use of language and narrative structure. These examples, set in the context of frontier operations, seem meant to show Julian as more martial and effective and so as a more legitimate emperor than Constantius. What we have here, then, is an ironical Ammianus.

To conclude, the historian's contextually dependent language, especially his dual meanings of *cunctator et cautus*, his frequent application of *ambigere/ambiguus* and the vocabulary of hesitation to Constantius and his military operations, and the latter's partiality for diplomacy, his singular use of *bellicosus dux* for Julian, which constitutes his highest military praise (not accorded to Constantius or Valentinian), and the typically varying degrees of territorial penetration of barbarian lands by each, all convey Ammianus' estimation of the quality of generalship and policies of both emperors on the northern frontiers. Constantius reacted

with reluctance to foreign incursions such as those of the Alamanni, Sarmatians, and Limigantes, stopping prematurely with a restrained response to the immediate problem and thinking short-term; but Julian was more aggressive and warlike, and sought out the gathering storms before they materialized.¹¹² For Ammianus, Julian's character, abilities, and preferences were perfectly highlighted by those of Constantius in a tale of two commanders. To emphasize Julian's superior military practices, Ammianus carefully crafted his tale further by omitting the full extent of Julian's ruthlessness and practice of taking enemy hostages following a victory, a practice Julian actually shared with Constantius. Such an intratextual reading of Ammianus as that made here through literary analysis has consequences for how we should read the historian, and it will necessitate further reevaluation of what we think Ammianus is telling us about both his subjects and himself.¹¹³

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¹¹²Cf. Amm. 18.2.1, 21.5.13.

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